

Area of Study 3F – Judaism

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Judaism as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about Philosophy of Religion and issues of equality and social justice.

There are four sections: Jewish Beliefs, Philosophy of Religion, Living the Jewish Life and Equality.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Jews today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how scripture informs a Jew's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Judaism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Judaism with Christianity as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.8)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.4)*

Students should recognise that Judaism is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Judaism and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Judaism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Judaism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Orthodox, Reform and Liberal traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The nature of the Almighty: how the characteristics of the Almighty are shown in the Torah, and why they are important in Jewish life today, including One, Creator, Law-Giver and Judge, including reference to <i>Genesis 2</i> .
1.2	The nature and importance of Shekhinah: how the divine presence is shown in the Torah and why it is important including interpretations of 2 Chronicles 7:1–3; the divergent understandings of Shekhinah found in different forms of Orthodox Judaism and the importance of them for Jews today.
1.3	The nature and purpose of the Messiah: how messiahship is shown in the scriptures, including Jeremiah 23:5–8; the nature and significance of the Messianic Age and the Jewish responsibility to bring it about; divergent understandings of the Messiah in different forms of Orthodox and Reform Judaism and the importance of them for Jewish people today.
1.4	The covenant with Abraham and his descendants: the nature and history of the Abrahamic covenant; the role of Abraham in the covenant, including <i>Genesis 17</i> ; why the Promised Land covenanted to Abraham and his descendants is important for Jews today.
1.5	The Covenant at Sinai: the nature and history of the Covenant at Sinai (the Ten Commandments), including <i>Exodus 20</i> ; the role and significance of Moses in the Covenant at Sinai; divergent understandings of how and why the Decalogue is important in Jewish life today.
1.6	Sanctity of life: why human life is holy for Jewish people; how life is shown as special. The nature and importance of Pikuach Nefesh (primacy of life): life takes precedence over everything, with reference to Talmud Yoma 83–84; divergent understandings of how and why the principle of Pikuach Nefesh is applied by Jews today.
1.7	Moral principles and the Mitzvot: the nature and importance of the Mitzvot, including reference to the Mishneh Torah of Maimonides: <i>Sefer Mada</i> ; the importance of the relationship between keeping the Mitzvot and free will; the Mitzvot between humans and the Almighty, and between humans; divergent understandings of the importance of the Mitzvot between the Almighty and humans, and between humans, for Jewish life today.
1.8*	Jewish beliefs about life after death: divergent Jewish understandings of the nature and significance of life after death including reference to different forms of Orthodox and Reform Judaism; Jewish teachings about life after death including interpretations of Ecclesiastes 12; the nature of resurrection and judgement; why belief in life after death may be important for Jews today.